

The DREAM SELLERS

UTV SPOTBOY For the first time, a big production house, Ronnie Screwvala's UTV, decides to dedicate a few crores to films that didn't exactly transcend the urban-rural divide but were powerful enough to deserve an audience. Launched in 2007, its first film was Rajkumar Gupta's *Aamir*, made on a budget of just Rs 2 crore. Others like *Welcome to Sajjanpur* and *Dev.D* followed.



ACTORS INC Much before Abhay Deol became the poster boy of indie films, the multiplex actor was already thriving. Ranvir

Shorey, Vinay Pathak and Rahul Bose all owe their stardom on the big screen to small films.



ANURAG KASHYAP For a long time, Kashyap was scared that he was jinxed. His first film *Paanchran* into Censor trouble and has still not been released. *Black Friday*, about the 1993 Mumbai blasts, got delayed by four years. But he stuck to his style and with *Dev.D* and *Gulal*, his hard-hitting narratives found an audience.



PRITISH NANDY Possibly one of the first producers to cash in on the multiplex boom, Nandy bankrolled *Jhankaar Beats*, a film about two friends and their band. Seeing potential in this genre, they have churned out *Bollywood Calling*, *Pyaar Ke Side Effects* and *Charneli*.



other way of making films. The only thing they understood is what is called over-the-table profits and for that you need a star to back your project. The stars obviously had a clear agenda and they believed that only a certain kind of film worked. The funny thing is that the facts pointed in the opposite direction. Those films did not work. A huge percentage of such films, whose only function was to please the audience, failed and could not recover their costs. Yet, the belief continued because no other 'formula' was available.

People have written enough about how the multiplex boom changed the world of independent cinema in the last decade. Well, not much changed in the first few years. The big mainstream films changed their stance a little, but only in terms of styling and design aesthetic, not the content. Other stuff would get a few odd shows at some odd hours. And still that was a change enough for the independent cinema. At least we could release our films and that was enough. A release, however small would mean at least some recovery through a sale to a satellite channel and home video market. And if there was a definite promise of a return, then the producers could be willing to risk it.

Also, the people who had given up on watching films at theatres in the 1980s and 1990s, who preferred to sit at home and watch either television or a video, started going to the cinema halls. And I believe this was our audience. Going to the cinema became a family activity again, a fun thing. And this audience wanted new stories or at least new ways of story telling. Ah, thank God.

And then, a freak hit here and there was enough of a signal to the producers that there was another formula to make films. They suddenly sat up and understood our logic. For me, the release of *Bheja Fry* in 2007 was a bizarre experience. Suddenly I



was getting calls from producers. I asked myself, "Is this really happening?" Of course, that too was just a phase, a dream that we had never dared to dream, and it ended last year when the markets tanked. The point is, that something has changed. Maybe it is not enough. But it is a start.

Are we witnessing a new wave? I don't think so. There was a new wave in France in the 1960s and in India in the 1970s. Now the 2000s are here. There are just a few individual filmmakers who can make the films they want to make, but there are very few of them, and I feel they are not trying hard enough. Not pushing the boundaries enough. If that doesn't change soon, I think it would be a great opportunity lost. Look at the last 10 years. How many films really made the mark? How many filmmakers? I can't think of more than four films or filmmakers and it tells a pathetic tale in a country that makes 900 films annually. Okay, so

Runway to SUCCESS



2001 Mira Nair's *Monsoon Wedding* premieres at the Venice film festival, becomes one of the most successful independent films by

an Indian filmmaker, earning \$30 million worldwide. This is three years after Nagesh Kukunoor's *Hyderabad Blues*.

2003 The little movie with big dreams comes into its own. *Jhankaar Beats*, a small production, becomes a big success in multiplexes.